

BUFFALO AND OTHER WILD CATTLE



THE FIVE SPECIES OF BUFFALO, and all other cattle, are members of the family Bovidae. They have split, or cloven, hooves, and both sexes have horns which they can use to defend themselves. The animals also gain some protection from living together in herds. Only the anoas are solitary animals. Cattle were among the earliest animals to be domesticated. The Asiatic buffalo, yak, banteng, and gaur all have a domesticated version. Loss of habitat, hunting, and diseases have drastically reduced the world's wild cattle. No fewer than nine of the eleven species are in danger of extinction.



American bison

The head, neck, and forequarters of the American bison are covered with long hair, which, with the large hump, makes the forequarters appear much bigger than the hindquarters. The horns are short and curved, and are grown by both sexes.



Plains bison

Bison

Often wrongly called buffalo, there are two species of bison. The American bison is a grassland animal which appears in two forms – the plains bison and the woods bison. The European bison, or wisent, is a forest dweller. Bison are massive animals standing more than 1.5 m (5 ft) tall and weighing more than 910 kg (2,000 lb).



European bison

The wisent lives in Poland's Bialowieza Forest. It is taller than the American bison and has a longer, less barrel-like body, and longer legs. Its hindquarters are also more powerfully built.

Oxen

The group of wild cattle commonly called oxen contains four species – the yak, the banteng, the gaur, and the kouprey. Domestic cattle also belong to this group. Most breeds of domestic cattle are descended from the now-extinct aurochs, which at one time inhabited the plains and woodlands of Europe and Asia in great numbers.

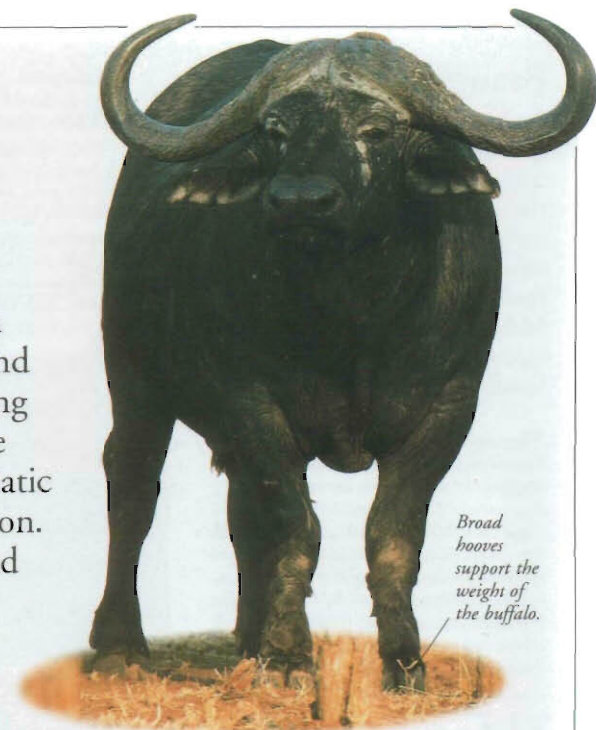


Yak

Largest of the wild cattle, the wild yak lives in herds high up on the Tibetan Plateau in Central Asia. To protect them against the bitterly cold climate, yaks have long, shaggy black hair reaching almost to the ground, with a thick undercoat.

Banteng

Found in Southeast Asia, Java, and Borneo, the banteng is a shy animal. Females and young are a brick-red colour; adult males are black.



African buffalo

The buffalo is the only species of wild cattle found in Africa. Cape buffalo bulls are up to 1.5 m (5 ft) at the shoulder and weigh more than 816 kg (1,800 lb). Their horns have a span of up to 1.5 m (5 ft) and form a massive helmet, or boss, across the head. A smaller subspecies, the forest buffalo, lives in equatorial forests.



Asiatic buffalo

There are four species of Asiatic buffalo – the water buffalo (shown here), the lowland and mountain anoa, and the tamarau. The water buffalo occurs in a domestic and a wild form, but only a few wild herds survive. Its horns are semi-circular and sweep outward and backward.

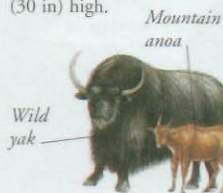
Endangered tamarau

Confined to the highlands on the island of Mindoro in the Philippines, this dwarf buffalo has been relentlessly hunted. Only about 100 survive today.



Largest and smallest

Wild cattle range in size from the wild yak, which is more than 2 m (6.5 ft) high at the shoulder, to the mountain anoa, which is no more than 76 cm (30 in) high.



CAPE BUFFALO

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Syncerus caffer*

ORDER Artiodactyla

FAMILY Bovidae

DISTRIBUTION Africa, south of the Sahara

HABITAT Grassland and woodland savannahs, but seldom far from water

DIET Mainly grass, occasionally supplemented with foliage

SIZE 1.5 m (5 ft) at the shoulder

LIFESPAN About 20 years

FIND OUT
MORE

DEER AND
ANTELOPES

FARMING

NORTH AMERICAN
WILDLIFE

SHEEP AND
GOATS